

You must be financially aware before your marriage and during it—you can't afford not to be. I don't care how capable you think your spouse is; you can lose everything in an instant if he or she screws up. Katrina was behind the scenes, working hard to keep the family happy and healthy, while her husband was out losing every cent of their hard-earned money. Had Katrina carved out her own business relationship with an independent financial advisor, she would have been able to protect herself *and* her kids. She might even have been able to steer Raj away from some very poor money decisions.

Money Mistake: *You Don't Have Your Own Financial Advisor*

The Fix: *Get One, Stat*

In my last book, I talked about your Secret 10. That's the 10 percent of your income that you're putting away and saving for later. I encouraged you to start saving that money while you were young and to keep growing it after you got married. Protecting your Secret 10 is the first step toward financial independence.

But now I'm taking it a step further. What do you do with your Secret 10 once it has grown into a substantial nest egg? How do you invest those funds? Simple: if you're not a financial expert yourself, you get help. You work alongside a qualified investment advisor who can put those funds to work for you. "But Kevin," you say, "we've already got an advisor. My husband (or wife) goes to see him all the time." If this were a test, you just failed it. *You must have your own investment advisor.* If you're married and you do not have an advisor independent of your partner, go out and find one this instant.

Ideally, you came into your marriage with some money. It may have been a lot or a little—whatever you'd been setting aside for your Secret 10. It is your job to ensure that money is being handled by an independent professional who is yours and yours alone. Don't entrust this job to anyone else. Think of it as your insurance policy. It shields you against financial disasters like the one Katrina